reality. She expresses her conceptualization of this idea in the form of an essay, merging prose and poetic lines to justify her argument against abstract reason and expression without grounding in existing struggle.[12] For example, in one conversation following a reading at Café Araquin, she tells audiences, “books … make bridges between people.”[13]

Emblematic of Lorde’s relationship to her poetry, and to the divided city of Berlin, was her ambivalent treatment of the Berlin Wall. Lorde engages the Wall in numerous writings to ponder its geopolitical relevance and its symbolic weight. She presents the Wall as both a spatial and temporal divide and a poetic manifestation of division to be countered with diffusion. From 1984 onward, the Berlin Wall would enter Lorde’s poetic language as a complex symbol of history and memory through which she addressed Cold War–era issues of division and difference, and solidarity and survival. At times, she would treat the Wall in abstract terms or turn her gaze to the broader implications of a divided geopolitical terrain; at other times, she would face it squarely in order to critically engage the structure and its implications. The fact that she returned to Berlin annually from 1986, while the Wall was up, through her final trip a month before her death in 1992, after reunification, affirms her strong connection to the city, as do the traces of German division included in all of her subsequent published projects. Throughout her work, she drew from her rituals and routines of exploring the divided city, imparting both her peaceful thoughts and her more volatile experiences.[14]

Lorde’s rendering of the Berlin Wall in her poems demands attention because she captures multiple forms of division on both sides of the divided city and eventually on both sides of the 1989 historical threshold. How she accounted for the Wall in language depended on the relative connections and sense of historical timing she wished to forge through her interdisciplinary modes of recollection. Bridging Freed’s and Davis’s often deliberately oblique reflections on the Berlin Wall, and Tajiri’s on-site excavations, Lorde adopted a range of similar tactics to underscore her poetic explorations of division, in and outside Berlin, navigating through official and alternative circuits of cultural exchange.

Lorde’s poems from *Our Dead Behind Us* and other writings from *A Burst of Light* forge connections between her Berlin-based self-reflection and her work across lines of difference and division, toward a practiced understanding of identity. The poet’s revisions of her writing, in and of the